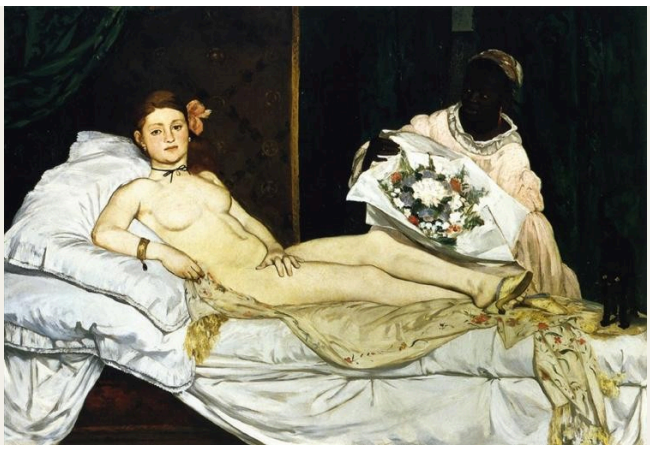
PARIS, FRANCE

Musée d’Orsay: Masterpieces

Funerals, floorboards and card games become substantial subjects in these twenty paintings.



Courbet's village funeral stretches across a canvas nearly seven metres wide. The size matters: a local community occupies the kind of space traditionally granted to grand historical or religious events. Elsewhere in this selection, workers kneel over floorboards, dancers wait between exercises and two men attend to a game of cards.

These paintings do not all make the same argument about modern life. Manet tests the conventions of the nude; Whistler emphasises an arrangement of tones; Cézanne makes a table's structure uncertain. What connects them here is the attention given to subjects and decisions that a hierarchy of grand themes could overlook. The useful question is what each painting asks an ordinary action, object or pose to carry.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/musee-orsay

The selection · 20

1. Olympia
   Édouard Manet · 1863
2. Luncheon on the Grass
   Édouard Manet · 1863
3. A Burial at Ornans
   Gustave Courbet · 1849–1850
4. The Gleaners
   Jean-François Millet · 1857
5. The Angelus
   Jean-François Millet · 1857–1859
6. Dance at the Moulin de la Galette
   Pierre-Auguste Renoir · 1876
7. The Floor Scrapers
   Gustave Caillebotte · 1875
8. Arrangement in Grey and Black No. 1: The Artist's Mother
   James Abbott McNeill Whistler · 1871
9. The Dance Class
   Edgar Degas · 1873–1876
10. Starry Night over the Rhône
    Vincent van Gogh · 1888
11. The Church at Auvers
    Vincent van Gogh · 1890 (painted 4–8 June 1890)
12. Dr Paul Gachet
    Vincent van Gogh · 1890
13. The Card Players
    Paul Cézanne · 1893-1896
14. Apples and Oranges
    Paul Cézanne · c. 1899
15. Arearea
    Paul Gauguin · 1892
16. Tahitian Women
    Paul Gauguin · 1891 (November–December)
17. Portrait of Edma Pontillon
    Berthe Morisot · 1871
18. Portrait of Émile Zola
    Édouard Manet · 1868
19. Frédéric Bazille Painting the Heron
    Pierre-Auguste Renoir · 1867
20. Juan Prim, 8 October 1868
    Henri Regnault · 1868

01 / 20

Olympia

Édouard Manet

1863 · Oil on canvas · Musée d'Orsay



Édouard Manet. Olympia. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The flowers arrive, but the woman's attention is directed out of the painting. That division gives the reclining pose an alertness absent from the idea of a sleeping Venus. Manet painted a contemporary sex worker, retaining a composition associated with idealised nudes while withholding its mythological excuse. Painted in 1863, the work caused a scandal when exhibited at the Salon in 1865.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Luncheon on the Grass

Édouard Manet

1863 · Oil on canvas · Musée d'Orsay



Édouard Manet. Le Déjeuner sur l'herbe. Image credit: Édouard Manet; Self-photographed. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Le_D%C3%A9jeuner_sur_l%27herbe_-_%C3%89douard_Manet.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The nude woman and the two dressed men do not seem to belong to the same social occasion. Manet makes no effort to resolve the discrepancy through mythology. Yet the composition draws on older art, including a group derived from Raphael through an engraving. Rejected by the Salon jury, the painting appeared at the Salon des Refusés in 1863: its challenge depended partly on familiar conventions put to unfamiliar use.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 1668

03 / 20

A Burial at Ornans

Gustave Courbet

1849–1850 · Oil on canvas · Musée d'Orsay



Gustave Courbet. A Burial at Ornans. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

At 6.68 metres wide, this village funeral occupies space usually reserved for elevated historical or religious subjects. Courbet distributes that space among mourners without appointing a commanding hero. The open grave brings the ceremony to the foreground as a physical fact. The subject's scale is therefore social as well as pictorial: ordinary people receive life-size treatment without being remade as ideal figures.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 325

04 / 20

The Gleaners

Jean-François Millet

1857 · Oil on canvas · Musée d’Orsay



Jean-François Millet. Des glaneuses ou Les glaneuses. Image credit: Jean-François Millet; Source credit: Google Arts & Culture — GgHsT2RumWxbtw. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The women collect what is left after the harvest, not the harvest itself. Millet makes that distinction visible by setting their handfuls against the abundance farther away. Their repeated bending connects the figures without turning them into interchangeable copies. The foreground gives exhausting, small-scale labour more pictorial weight than the larger operation in the distance.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 592

05 / 20

The Angelus

Jean-François Millet

1857–1859 · Oil on canvas · Musée d’Orsay



Jean-Francois Millet. L’Angélus. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

The tools and basket remain beside the figures, so the prayer has the character of an interruption rather than a separate ceremony. Lowered heads turn attention towards the gap between the man and woman. The distant church places that private pause within a wider setting. Millet makes stillness legible through the work that has temporarily stopped.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 1877

06 / 20

Dance at the Moulin de la Galette

Pierre-Auguste Renoir

1876 · Oil on canvas · Musée d'Orsay



Pierre-Auguste Renoir. Bal du moulin de la Galette. Image credit: Sailko; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Pierre_auguste_renoir,_ballo_del_moulin_del_la_galette,_1876,_01.JPG. CC BY 3.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC BY 3.0

Light crosses the boundaries between people. Its scattered patches touch faces, clothing and ground, connecting separate conversations and dancing couples without requiring a single main event. The seated foreground offers points of entry into the crowd; farther back, attention disperses. Renoir's gathering remains sociable partly because no one figure claims the whole picture.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 2739

07 / 20

The Floor Scrapers

Gustave Caillebotte

1875 · Oil on canvas · Musée d'Orsay



Gustave Caillebotte. The Parquet Planers (The Floor Scrapers). Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The floorboards set the direction of the work. Their long strips pull attention into the room, while the kneeling men move across them at different stages of the same task. Light from the window distinguishes scraped wood and bare backs. Caillebotte gives manual labour a measured setting without concealing the awkward bodily positions that it requires.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

Arrangement in Grey and Black No. 1: The Artist's Mother

James Abbott McNeill Whistler

1871 · Musée d'Orsay



James Abbott McNeill Whistler. Arrangement in Grey and Black No.1, Portrait of the Artist's Mother. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The title asks for attention to an arrangement as well as a person. Large areas of grey and black establish the portrait before the smaller pale accents of face, cap and hands become distinct. The framed picture and patterned curtain help divide the wall. These decisions do not cancel the sitter's presence; they give her quiet profile its unusually firm setting.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

The Dance Class

Edgar Degas

1873–1876 · Oil on canvas · Musée d'Orsay



Edgar Degas. The Ballet Class. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

A dance class contains much more than dancing. Some figures practise, while others wait, rest or adjust their clothes. The open floor gives these small activities room to remain separate, even as the instructor and lesson hold the group together. Degas treats disciplined performance as the product of uneven attention, repetition and intervals between movements.

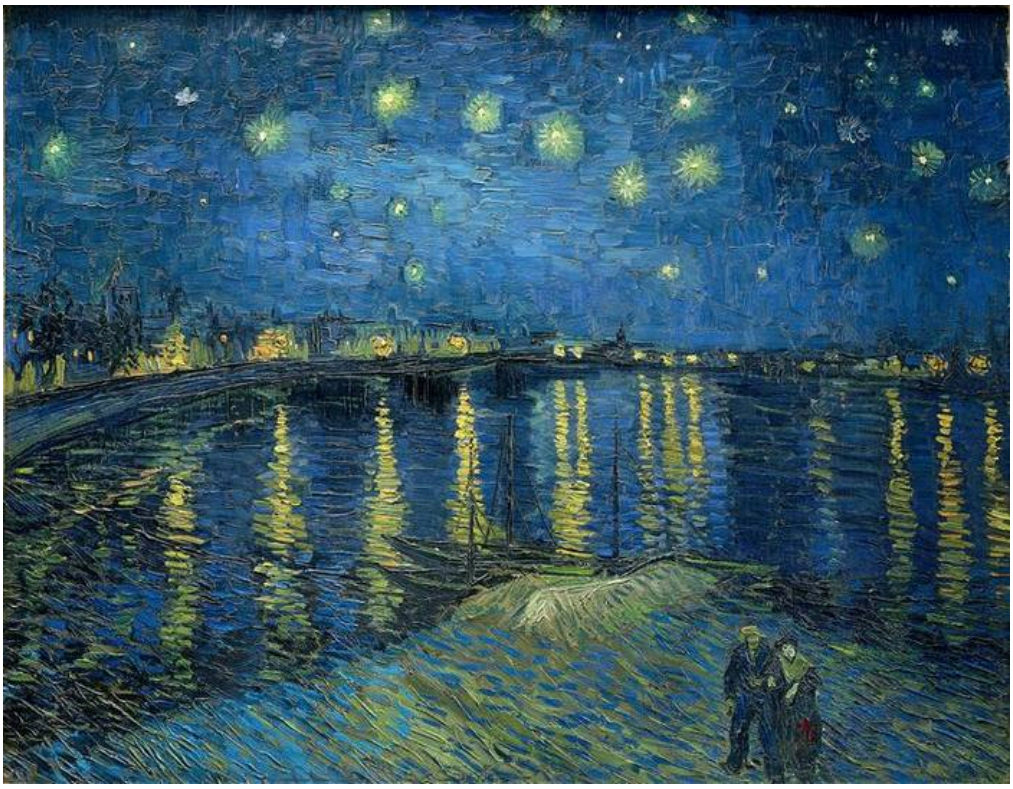
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 1976

10 / 20

Starry Night over the Rhône

Vincent van Gogh

1888 · Oil on canvas · Musée d'Orsay



Vincent van Gogh. La Nuit étoilée. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

Two kinds of light occupy the night: scattered stars above and the city's long reflections below. The distinction keeps sky and river separate even where their colours approach one another. Near the bank, the couple supplies a scale against which the broad water can be understood. The scene is expansive, but it retains a place for two small figures.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 1975 19

11 / 20

The Church at Auvers

Vincent van Gogh

1890 (painted 4–8 June 1890) · Oil on canvas · Musée d'Orsay



Vincent van Gogh. L'église d'Auvers-sur-Oise, vue du chevet. Image credit: Sailko; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Vincent_Van_Gogh,_la_chiesa_di_auvers-sur-oise,_1890,_01.JPG. CC BY 3.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC BY 3.0

The paths divide around the church, offering routes past a building whose outlines seem less stable than its masonry should allow. Walls bend beneath the deep blue sky; the small walking figure belongs to a different scale of movement. Van Gogh keeps the church recognisable while drawing its contours into the surrounding landscape's activity.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 1951 42

12 / 20

Dr Paul Gachet

Vincent van Gogh

1890 · Oil on canvas · Musée d'Orsay



Vincent van Gogh. Le Docteur Paul Gachet. Image credit: GFreihalter; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Paris_7e_Mus%C3%A9e_d%E2%80%99Orsay_Van_Gogh_%C3%A0_Auvers-sur-Oise_981.jpg. CC BY-SA 4.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC BY-SA 4.0

Gachet's hand supports his head rather than making a gesture towards someone else. Sloping shoulders and the diagonal body repeat that downward pressure, while the flowers beside him hold a more upright position. Weariness is a plausible reading of the pose. It does not establish a medical condition or supply a diagnosis of the sitter.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 1949 16

13 / 20

The Card Players

Paul Cézanne

1893-1896 · Oil on canvas · Musée d'Orsay



Paul Cezanne. Les Joueurs de cartes. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

The bottle establishes a vertical division without making the two men mirror images. Their different postures settle on either side of the narrow table, with attention directed towards the cards rather than the viewer. Cézanne finds a sustained subject in that concentration. Little needs to happen for the balance between the figures to remain worth examining.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 1969

14 / 20

Apples and Oranges

Paul Cézanne

c. 1899 · Oil on canvas · Musée d'Orsay



Paul Cézanne. Pommes et oranges. Image credit: Sailko; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Paul_c%C3%A9zanne,_mele_e_arance,_1899_ca._01.JPG. CC BY 3.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC BY 3.0

The fruit appears solid even though the table is difficult to reconstruct as a single, consistent surface. Plates, folds and the raised dish introduce competing angles. Rather than treating those shifts simply as faulty perspective, follow how each gives an object more room to be seen. Cézanne's arrangement holds together through local relationships rather than one fixed viewpoint.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 1972

15 / 20

Arearea

Paul Gauguin

1892 · Oil on canvas · Musée d'Orsay



Paul Gauguin. Arearea. Image credit: Sailko; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Paul_gauguin,_arearea,_1892,_01.JPG. CC BY 3.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC BY 3.0

The red dog makes it difficult to mistake this setting for a neutral report of what Gauguin saw. Bands of colour organise the ground around the seated women; smaller figures occupy another register behind them. Simplification gives the scene coherence, but it also declares the painter's intervention. The work should not stand in for an unmediated account of Tahitian life.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 1961 6

16 / 20

Tahitian Women

Paul Gauguin

1891 (November–December) · Oil on canvas · Musée d'Orsay



Paul Gauguin. Femmes de Tahiti. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

The two seated women have different directions of attention. One turns sideways while the other faces outward, so their closeness does not become a matched pose. Broad outlines and the restricted depth give their bodies weight. Hands and patterned clothing provide smaller distinctions within that compact arrangement, keeping the pair from becoming merely a repeated shape.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 2765

17 / 20

Portrait of Edma Pontillon

Berthe Morisot

1871 · Oil on canvas · Musée d'Orsay



Berthe Morisot. Portrait of Edma Pontillon. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/berthe-morisot/portrait-of-edma-pontillon · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Dark clothing could make the seated figure seem like a single block, but Morisot separates hands, face and dress through small changes of light. The slight turn of the head counters the hands resting together. Pale patterned furnishings give those restrained movements a setting. The portrait's specificity depends on such adjustments rather than a conspicuous gesture.

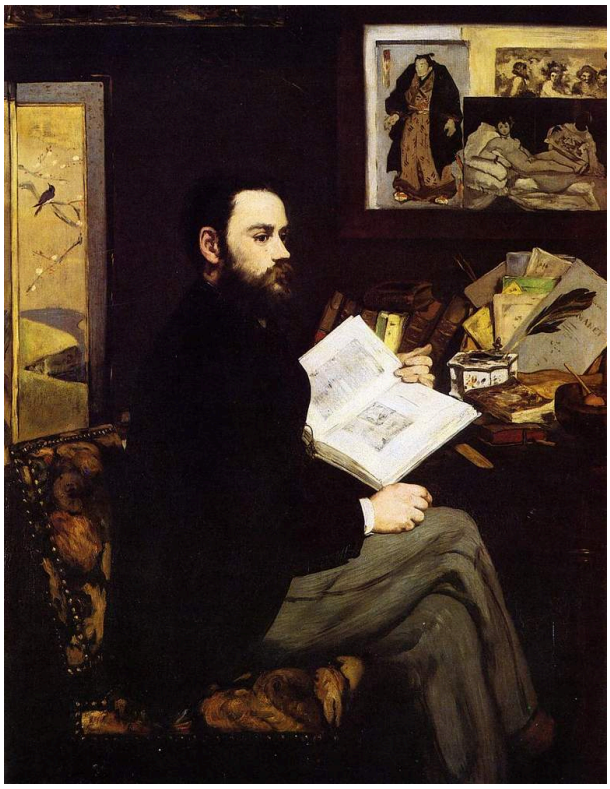
Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

Portrait of Émile Zola

Édouard Manet

1868 · Oil on canvas · Musée d’Orsay



Édouard Manet. Portrait of Emile Zola. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/edouard-manet/portrait-of-emile-zola-1868 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The open book and images on the wall make looking and reading part of the portrait's subject. They surround Zola without dissolving his sharply drawn profile into an inventory of interests. Manet holds the physical sitter and the intellectual setting in the same frame. The objects invite attention, but they do not explain everything about the person.

Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

Frédéric Bazille Painting the Heron

Pierre-Auguste Renoir

1867 · Oil on canvas · Musée d’Orsay



Frederic Bazille Painting The Heron (Frederic Bazille at his Easel). WikiArt; Pierre-Auguste Renoir. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Bazille is occupied with making an image rather than presenting himself for one. The side view lets his leaning body, brush and nearby materials define the activity. Renoir turns a colleague's ordinary working posture into the basis of a portrait. Professional identity appears through a task in progress, not through a formal declaration of status.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Juan Prim, 8 October 1868

Henri Regnault

1868 · Oil · Musée d’Orsay



Henri Regnault. Juan Prim, October 8, 1868. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/henri-regnault/juan-prim-october-8-1868-1868 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The raised foreleg prevents the horse from becoming a static platform beneath Prim. Its restless movement makes the rider's composure more conspicuous, while people and flags locate the scene beyond the immediate pair. Regnault uses a familiar form of public authority, the equestrian portrait, but its effect depends on keeping the animal visibly active.

Object source · Open artwork

Compare kinds of attention

Place the card players beside Degas's dancers, or Bazille at work beside Zola reading. Concentration, waiting and self-presentation each produce a different kind of portrait. These comparisons are more useful than treating every work as a step towards a single modern style. Check the museum's current information before visiting: a selection from its holdings does not guarantee that every painting is on display.

Further reading

Impressionism: A Centenary Exhibition

Anne Dayez, Michel Hoog and Charles S. Moffett · Read online or download · English

Impressionism: A Centenary Exhibition places works by Monet, Renoir, Degas and their contemporaries in the setting of the early Impressionist exhibitions. The Met provides the catalogue online.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

Artline · Musée d'Orsay: Masterpieces